

Defense of PhD Dissertation  
*The semantics of Udmurt spatial  
cases*

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# Overall assessment of the dissertation

- solid and deep control of theoretical framework, drawing additionally on psychology and neurology
- knowledge and documentation facts of Udmurt
- semantic analysis of the spatial cases of Udmurt
- first ever to provide quantitative data on the distribution of senses within Udmurt spatial cases, and first to approach this topic following traditions of Cognitive Linguistics
- illustrated with 379 authentic examples, all supplied with Leipzig glossing and translations

# Overview of questions

- Questions posed in Preliminary Examiner's Statement
- Other questions about the dissertation
- Concluding questions about this line of research

# Questions posed in Preliminary Examiner's Statement

Where is possible rivalry in the system, both among spatial cases and with other cases?

# This example uses relative, but could inessive be used?

(180) Udmurt dunne (10.04.2007)

|                         |                 |                     |                   |                |
|-------------------------|-----------------|---------------------|-------------------|----------------|
| <i>Višon-li</i>         | <i>u-g</i>      | <i>šot-sk-o</i>     | <i>pešaj-jos:</i> | <i>gurt</i>    |
| sickness-DAT            | NEG.PRS-3       | give-DTR-CNG.PL     | old.woman-PL      | <b>village</b> |
| <i>kotir-iš</i>         | <i>už-zes</i>   | <i>no</i>           | <i>uža-lo,</i>    | <i>vañmon</i>  |
| <b>surroundings-ELA</b> | work-ACC.PX.3PL | CNJ                 | work-PRS.3PL      | free           |
| <i>dır-zes</i>          | <i>no</i>       | <i>vožjaški-mon</i> | <i>ortčit-o.</i>  |                |
| time-ACC.PX.3PL         | CNJ             | envy-PTCP7          | spend-PRS.3PL     |                |

‘The old women are not giving up to sickness: They both do the work around the household [lit. village], and spend free time until envying [i.e., enviably].’

This example uses egressive, but could inessive be used?

(205) Udmurt dunne (23.10.2007)

*Munčo-išen so-je vu pušk-i kušt-o, noš boriš siče*  
**sauna-EGR 3SG-ACC water inside-ILL throw-PRS.3PL CNJ later that.kind**  
*vu-en gilt-išk-o.*  
**water-INS wash-DTR-PRS.3PL**

‘In the sauna they throw it [a coin] in the water, and later they wash themselves with that [kind of] water.’

# What is the overall frequency (both ipm and relative) of the Udmurt spatial cases?

- For example, is egressive more frequent than elative?
- What is the relative frequency of source vs. goal cases?
  - Note that some have claimed that goal-orientation prevails in language



# Why are some similar meanings/uses classified differently?

- For example, for the elative case there are five examples of uses that signal people from someplace (149, 152, 171, 175, 178), yet all of these have been annotated differently -- why?

# Why are idiomatic uses termed “periphery constructions”?

- Does this term come from Schmid 2014?
- Do idiomatic uses play any important role in the system, or should they be set aside?
  - p. 119 на солнце *šundĭ vĭl-ĭn* [sun top-INE]
  - p. 247 под суд *sud ul-e* [trial under-ILL]
  - p. 184 *ulonĭś koškĭnĭ* ‘die [lit. leave from life]’
  - p. 200 *Nunal-ĭś nunal-e* [day-ELA day-ILL] from day to day

Other questions about the  
dissertation

p. 57

Table 2: There is a desinence of -Ø cited for the illative.  
What is your understanding of zero morphemes?

“only content nouns with inanimate referents can be inflected in spatial cases”

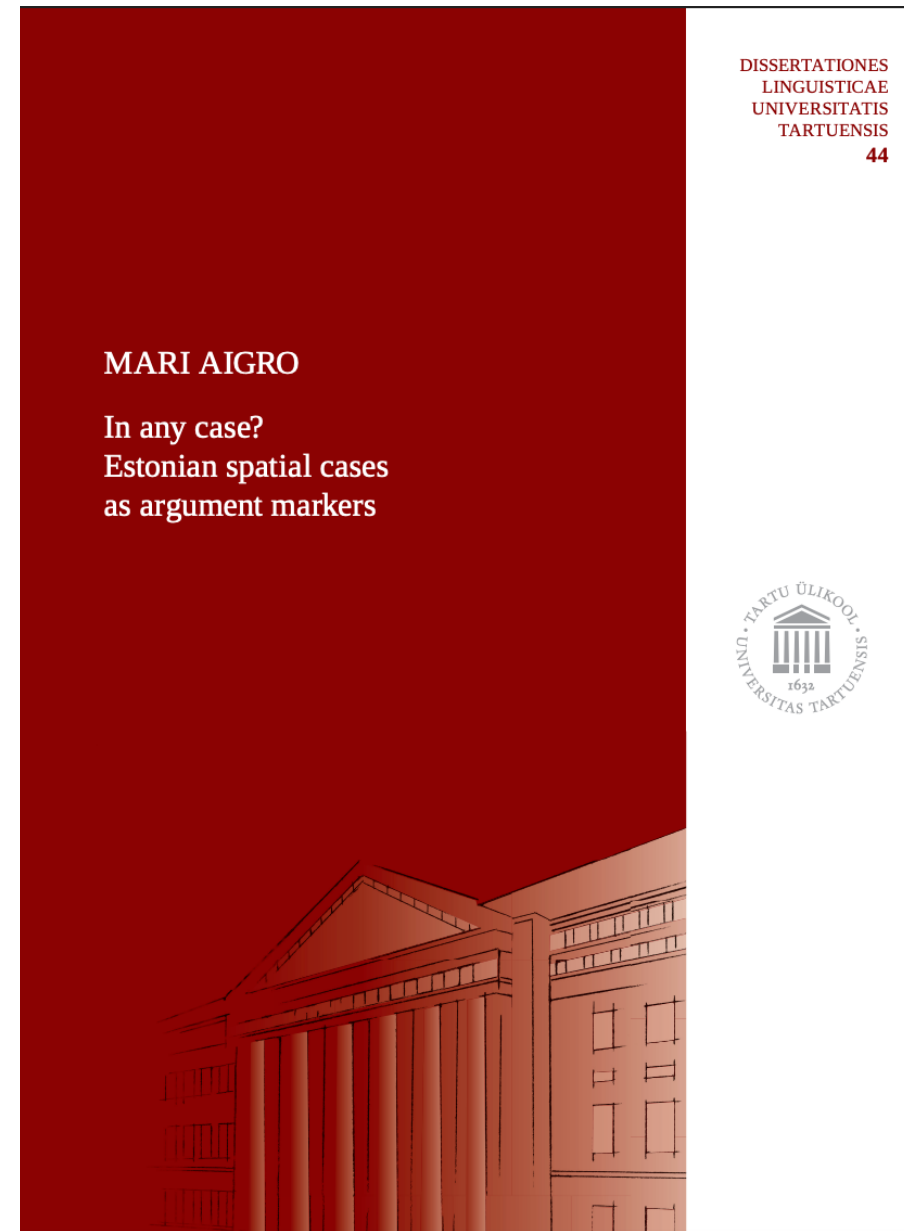
So how are spatial relations with animates expressed? By adpositions?

# Aigro 2022 PhD dissertation on Estonian spatial cases

14 cases in Estonian

- 3 are “structural” (aka “syntactic”, “grammatical”) cases mark core argument roles: nominative, partitive, genitive
- 11 are “semantic”, of these
  - 6 are spatial cases: illative ‘into’, inessive ‘in’, elative ‘out of’, allative ‘onto’, adessive ‘on’, ablative ‘from on’

Spatial cases can sometimes be used to mark core argument roles (see next slide), and the structural cases sometimes appear in adverbials.



# Aigro 2022 PhD dissertation on Estonian spatial cases

- (1) a. Enno kõndi-s bussijaama-st koju  
Enno.NOM walk-PST.3SG bus station-ELA home.ILL  
‘Enno walked home from the bus station’
- b. Üritus sõltu-b ilma-st  
event.NOM depend-PRS.3SG weather-ELA  
‘The event depends on the weather’

“semantic”

“structural”

# Comparing Estonian and Udmurt spatial cases

Is there any “leakage” in Udmurt, are there uses of spatial cases to mark argument roles?

If not, why would Udmurt be different from Estonian?

Aigro suggests that the use of spatial cases with human referents leads to the bleaching of spatial cases and grammaticalization to mark argument roles. What do you think of this?

# Talmyan classification, caused-motion, resultatives

Is Udmurt verb-framed or satellite-framed? How does this play out with respect to spatial cases?

Are there caused-motion or resultative uses? Is ex (37) on p. 89 an example of resultative?

(37) Udmurt dunne (11.11.2009)

*Kalik gur+r! šerekja, noš Saša peš-e vu-i-z.*

people INJ laugh.PRS.3SG CNJ PN **heat-ILL** arrive-PST1-3SG

‘People laugh “Hahaha!”, but Saša becomes ashamed [lit. arrives to heat].’



Relational nouns: *vil*- ‘top’, *dor*- ‘near’-, *pum*- ‘end’, *bord*- ‘next, near’, *ul*- ‘under’

- What is the LM? Is it the noun modified by the relational noun or just the relational noun?
- I get the sense that SURFACE vs. CONTAINER is disambiguated by relational noun *vil*- ‘top’ – is that correct?

# Role of other factors in case semantics

- Why should the meanings of verbs (e.g. translocational motion vs. other) and forms of verbs (e.g. finite vs. converb) be taken into account when distinguishing the meanings of the cases?

# Is the meaning of starting and source given by the verb, not the case in these exx.?

(83) Udmurt dunne (25.01.2012)

|                          |            |                 |                    |                                  |
|--------------------------|------------|-----------------|--------------------|----------------------------------|
| <i>Kal'l'en+kal'l'en</i> | <i>už</i>  | <i>dur-a-m</i>  | <i>projekt-jos</i> | <i>śot-ja-nj</i>                 |
| slowly+slowly            | work       | edge-LOC-PX.1SG | project-PL         | give-FRQ-INF                     |
| <i>kutsk-i-zj,</i>       | <i>ožj</i> | <i>vetlj-nj</i> | <i>kutsk-i</i>     | <i>komand'irovka-os-ti</i> (...) |
| start-PST1-PX.3PL        | CNJ        | travel-INF      | start-PST1.1SG     | <b>work.trip-PL-PRL</b>          |

‘Little by little they started to give projects at [lit. the edge of] my work, so I started to travel on [lit. along] work trips.’

(86) Udmurt dunne (27.07.2016)

|                   |                  |                    |               |                 |             |              |
|-------------------|------------------|--------------------|---------------|-----------------|-------------|--------------|
| – <i>Gurt-len</i> | <i>kjldem-ez</i> | <i>śariś</i>       | <i>tače</i>   | <i>l'egenda</i> | <i>vañ:</i> | <i>čigan</i> |
| village-GEN       | birth-PX.3SG     | about              | this.kind     | legend          | EXT.PRS     | Roma         |
| <i>njl.kjšno</i>  | <i>ta-ti</i>     | <i>nunj-jen-iz</i> | <i>košk-e</i> | <i>vjlem.</i>   |             |              |
| woman             | <b>here-PRL</b>  | child-INS-PX.3SG   | leave-PRS.3SG | EXT.PST2        |             |              |

‘– There is such a legend about the birth of the village: A Roma woman had apparently left along here with her child.’

# Does encyclopedic knowledge play a role in case semantics?

(373) Kondrat'eva (2011: 198) / Ext.

|                            |            |               |                       |
|----------------------------|------------|---------------|-----------------------|
| <i>Mjn-išk-o</i>           | <i>mon</i> | <i>Iževsk</i> | <b><i>uram-ti</i></b> |
| go-PRS-1SG                 | 1SG        | PLN           | <b>street-PRL</b>     |
| 'I go along Iževsk street' |            |               |                       |

(374) Kondrat'eva (2011: 199) / Ext.

|                                                        |                         |           |                  |       |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------|------------------|-------|
| <i>Gurt-e</i>                                          | <b><i>gumi-jeti</i></b> | <i>vu</i> | <i>pirt-i-zi</i> | (...) |
| village-ILL                                            | <b>pipe-PRL</b>         | water     | bring-PST1-1PL   |       |
| 'They bring the water to the village via a pipe (...)' |                         |           |                  |       |

# Terms for the meanings of the cases overlap

- For example, for prolative we have: Path, Location (path), and Place (path)
- Are the differences really crisp or are they more gradual?
  - cf. “Example (116) elaborates the schema of PLACE completely, but these kind of examples can be considered bridging contexts between PATH and PLACE.” [this suggests gradual transitions among the meanings]
  - Section 7.1.2 seems to regard overlaps in the semantic structure of spatial cases as a problem, but shouldn’t overlaps be expected in language? Isn’t it often the case that languages allow for multiple ways to encode the “same” realia?
- See examples of meanings that are classed differently but seem very similar on next 5 pages...

## Prolative (going to a number of places)

- p. 126 (74) *avto.salon-jos-ti* [car.dealership-PL-PRL] Path(Middle)
- p. 132 (83) *komand'irovka-os-ti* [work.trip-PL-PRL] Path(source)
- p. 139 (95) *koncert-jos-ti* [concert-PL-PRL] Location(Path)

## Elative (people from various places)

- p. 178 (149) *Ot-i ś* [there-ELA] Whole(Origin) ‘friends from there’
- p. 181 (152) *nĭl.pi jurt-i ś* [child house-ELA] Source (Other) ‘boy from orphanage’
- p. 192 (171, mislabeled as L9) *Baškiri-i ś* [PLN-ELA] Location(Origin) ‘she from Bashkortostan’
- p. 195 (175) *pe rtem sereg-jos-i śt-i z* [different corner-PL-ELA-PX.3SG] Place(Source) ‘friends from different corners of the country’
- p. 197 (178) *ot-i ś* [there-ELA] ambiguous case between PLACE and ORIGIN ‘worshippers from there’

## Egressive (from a street)

- p. 220 (206) *Kirov ul'čá-j'šen* [PLN street-EGR] Place
- p. 228 (217) *Babuškin ul'čá-j'šen* [PLN street-EGR] Mental process



## Illative (to work)

- p. 246 (241) *už-e* [work-ILL] Goal
- p. 250 (250) *už-e* [work-ILL] Goal (Endpoint)

# Approximative (here and there)

- p. 329 (360) *so-lań+ta-lań* [there-APR+here-APR] Direction and Place
- p. 332 (365) *so-lań+ta-lań* [there-APR+here-APR] Location
- p. 335 (369) *so-lań+ta-lań* [there-APR+here-APR] Place

# Fictive motion: is this relevant for more exx.?

Several exx. are identified in introductory chapters as fictive motion, for example (17):

(17) Udmurt dunne 17.04.2009 / Ext.

– *Ma, kapka až-išen adž-išk-e uk: kjk gurež, o-ti*  
PCL gate front-EGR see-DTR-PRS.3SG PCL two mountain there-PRL  
*śures mĭn-e.*  
**road go-PRS.3SG**

‘– Well, it can be seen from the gate [lit. from the gate onwards]: Two mountains, there goes a road.’

But otherwise fictive motion does not figure in the dissertation much. Maybe more could be done iwth this concept?

## Other possible exx. of fictive motion?

- p. 147 (111) *šur-ti* *viž-ez* [river-PRL bridge-ACC] ‘bridge **over river**’
- p. 220 (206) *Kirov ul'čā-i šen* [PLN street-EGR] ‘Pushkin street is closed **from Kirov street**’
- p. 223 (211) *5-i šen* [five-EGR] ‘(the number increased) **from 5** to 7’
- p. 224 (212) *21 nunal-i šen* [21 day-EGR] ‘lasts **from 21** to 90-100 **days**’
- p. 231 (222) *Trassa-i šen* [highway-EGR] ‘the road **from the highway** to Izgurt’
- p. 232 (223) *Čimošur-i šen* [PLN-EGR] ‘the mountain stretches **from Čimošur** to Spring Hill’
- p. 266 (277) *škola-je* [school-ILL] ‘roads leading **to the school**’

## pp. 54, 55

“If children learn to connect linguistic elements to categories, the categories must be non-linguistic.”

“...there is a structured conception of space and spatial configurations in human cognition, and this structure is systematically mapped onto language. These presuppositions also underlie this study. The basic human conception of space and spatial configurations is not dependent on language, but rather is prelinguistic”

Are these necessary assumptions? Couldn't it be possible for linguistic and non-linguistic categories to co-evolve? Even if human perception is universal, could conception be different? And is it possible to distinctly untangle perception and conception?

Concluding questions about this  
line of research

Imagine you are a teacher...

If you were teaching someone the Udmurt spatial cases, how would you do it?

Imagine a perfect world with unlimited resources and no wars...

If you had unlimited resources to continue this line of research, what would you do? What kind of research would you do if you could go to Russia/Udmurtia?



What has changed?

How have your ideas changed over the course of your research?

What would you have done differently?

Circling back to the main point...

What does this research tell us about language in general (not just Udmurt)?